

Fairlington Historical Society
September 11, 2001 Oral History Interview
Kerry McKenney & Laura Parker

Martha Herrmann: Hi, I'm Martha Herrmann with the Fairlington Historical Society. And I'm here today with

Kerry McKenney: Kerry McKinney.

Martha Herrmann: And

Laura Parker: Laura Parker.

Martha Herrmann: And we're going to talk about September 11, 2001, as they both were living here in Fairlington then. Laura, where were you living exactly at the time?

Laura Parker: Right here in this house.

Martha Herrmann: Right here on 30th Street?

Laura Parker: Yes.

Martha Herrmann: And Carrie, you too?

Kerry McKenney: Yes.

Martha Herrmann: And that was 25 years ago. Can you believe it?

Kerry McKenney: I can't.

Laura Parker: I can't either.

Martha Herrmann: 25 years ago. About how old were you all then? Were you little children?

Kerry McKenney: I was 50-ish.

Martha Herrmann: Okay.

Laura Parker: You were a little younger.

Kerry McKenney: I was probably 45-ish.

Martha Herrmann: Okay. Tell me, I want to hear from both of you what in general your normal mornings were like.

Kerry McKenney: Well, we both worked on Capitol Hill, so a normal morning would be, we usually commuted together. So, I worked for the House of Representatives side. Laura worked for the Senate side. And I would go in and look at the schedule to see what was going on that day, to see what the member of Congress I worked for was doing, and if there was a press conference because I did the press. Just what the day would look like. And

Martha Herrmann: Who was the congressman you worked for?

Kerry McKenney: His name was Donald Payne from New Jersey.

Martha Herrmann: Oh. And Laura, who were you working for?

Laura Parker: I was working for the Senate Sergeant at Arms. And he was on day four of becoming the Sergeant at Arms. The majority leader of the Senate appoints the Sergeant at Arms, according to what party is in power. So, the party just changed from Republican to Democratic, and Senator Daschle was the Senate majority leader. So, Mr. Linehart was there, day four.

Kerry McKenney: Of his new job.

Laura Parker: So, that day, when a new Sergeant at Arms comes in, we're all there to help him get acclimated and make sure he's got a phone and a typewriter and a desk and everything. So, I was early to work that day, probably

Martha Herrmann: What time did you all normally go into work?

Kerry McKenney: I usually started at 9:00.

Laura Parker: 9:00.

Kerry McKenney: 9:00 a.m.

Martha Herrmann: So, you would leave here what, 8:30, something like that?

Kerry McKenney: Well, supposed to.

Laura Parker: Supposed to, yes.

Kerry McKenney: Sometimes earlier though, if there was something going on.

Scarlett Bunting: Did you drive or take the bus?

Kerry McKenney: Drove. We had parking places because both of us worked late and it was the later in the day it gets, the harder it is to use public transportation, especially from here because you have to go, as you probably know, to the Pentagon and then wait there, take a bus home. Yeah.

Martha Herrmann: So, the morning of September 11, 2001, you drove together like normal?

Laura Parker: Like normal, yes.

Martha Herrmann: And what time, do you remember?

Kerry McKenney: Did we drive together?

Laura Parker: I might have gone separately because I

Kerry McKenney: I think we drove separately because you came home so late at night.

Martha Herrmann: So, you left before 8:30 or after?

Laura Parker: I probably left at 7:30 that day, to be there at 8:00.

Martha Herrmann: And you?

Kerry McKenney: And I probably left at 8:30.

Martha Herrmann: So, you left before hearing or knowing anything?

Laura Parker: Right.

Kerry McKenney: Right.

Martha Herrmann: So, when did you each first hear that something had happened?

Kerry McKenney: Well, I can tell you what happened to me. I was at my desk, working on something, and I shared an office with a young woman. And she said to me, she goes, Kerry, a plane just hit the World Trade Center. And she sounded kind of alarmed and I looked up and the World Trade Center was so big and imposing. It just looked like a little private plane had accidentally hit the thing and she was very anxious about it. And I said, her name was Alex. I said, Alex, I don't think you have anything to worry about. I think it was just an accident. Looks like a small plane. And so, as we're talking about it, I look up and I see the second plane hit. And I'm like, oh my god.

Martha Herrmann: And this was because you had a TV on in the

Kerry McKenney: We had a TV on and normally we would switch to the proceedings of the House floor, and the House usually went into session around 10:00, but we watched the news up until then. So, we watched the whole thing and once the second plane hit, it was a moment of disbelief like that would be too big a coincidence that two planes would hit that morning. So, that's when I said, oh Alex, I think you're right. And then within minutes, the Capitol Police came knocking on the door: everybody out, out, out right now. And we evacuated the building.

Martha Herrmann: Where'd you go?

Kerry McKenney: Well, this was kind of crazy. They sent us, there's a park right in back of the Rayburn Building where our office was. A big park. So, we're all out there like sitting ducks. I mean, it seemed, it didn't seem very safe to be out there when, and planes continued to go by, but they were from the Pentagon, but we didn't know at the time if it was another terrorist plane or what it was. So, it was very unsettling.

Martha Herrmann: Laura, how did you first hear?

Laura Parker: Well, the Capitol Police, the Sergeant at Arms is on the Capitol Police Board, which is made up of the House Sergeant at Arms and the Senate Sergeant at Arms and the Architect of the Capitol. So, they had oversight over the Capitol Police. So, they're in and out of our office all the time. So, the chief of the Capitol Police showed up in the office to let Mr. Linhart know what was going on, what they were hearing. And I can't remember what time it was at that time.

Kerry McKenney: Did you have a TV on in the

Laura Parker: Yeah, we had a TV.

Martha Herrmann: So, what did you think? Did anyone expressly say to you or did you know what had happened at that point?

Laura Parker: Well, I knew. I saw it on TV as well. So, the police were all over us and calling and into the office and I guess they were making the decision of whether to evacuate the Capitol.

Martha Herrmann: Now, what about when the plane hit the Pentagon?

Laura Parker: We were in our office and Mr. Linhart was a former general in the Army. And he said, my colleagues, and he went over to the window to look because our office was facing the Pentagon. He could see what was going on there. So,

Martha Herrmann: Did they make you all evacuate as well?

Laura Parker: They did.

Martha Herrmann: And where did you evacuate to?

Laura Parker: We went to the plaza on the east side of the Capitol with people who were in our wing of the Capitol. We were close to the House side. We were close to the very middle. And so, some of the Architect's staff were out there. And like Kerry, I heard this big plane come over, and I thought this is it. I looked at this person I barely knew. I said, Amita, I think this is it. It's been nice knowing you. Because I thought the bomb was coming right there.

Scarlett Bunting: Right. Right.

Martha Herrmann: And could you see from where you were that the Pentagon had already been hit? So, could you see anything, the smoke or anything?

Laura Parker: Yes. I could when I was in the office, but

Kerry McKenney: And then it was really eerie driving to work the next day. The smoke was coming from the Pentagon and going across the highway. And it made it all the more real to see the aftermath.

Martha Herrmann: So, going back to that day, did you both stay on the hill for the day?

Kerry McKenney: No. We

Martha Herrmann: Kerry, you didn't?

Kerry McKenney: No. No, we were not allowed back in the building, at least initially. And people wanted to go get their cars and I think it was a long time before I finally did get in to get my car, but it was late afternoon.

Martha Herrmann: And how'd you get home?

Kerry McKenney: I drove.

Martha Herrmann: But what was the route you had to take? Could you come across the bridge?

Kerry McKenney: Well, my regular bridge at, yeah, 14th Street.

Martha Herrmann: Oh wow. So, it wasn't blocked or

Kerry McKenney: Not at that hour because, so, what happened, I had made plans in advance to meet a friend at the Monocle. That was the fancy...

Martha Herrmann: I remember that.

Kerry McKenney: The Monocle is a bar restaurant on the Senate side of Capitol Hill. Popular hangout. So, I had made arrangements to meet a friend for lunch. And so, when this happened, well, I should back up. Before that, after everybody in the park sort of dispersed at some point, and so I was on the street and a woman who worked for my former boss, and they had a business on Capitol Hill, came out. She was looking for people she knew to invite them in to watch it on TV and to sort of get us out of harm's way. So, I went in and there were other friends in there and we all sat down and watched everything on TV. And anyway, then I went to meet my friend for lunch. So, I walked over there to the Monocle, and D Street where it's located was blocked. I mean, they had police there saying you can't enter. And I said, well, I'm meeting someone. And so, just then a congressman, Congressman Jim Saxton, very nice guy, happened to be walking by. I mean, he was trying to figure out how to get home too. And I said, I got to get into the Monocle. And so, he said to the Capitol policeman, let her in. And when a member of Congress speaks, they listen. So, I did ultimately go down D Street, went into the Monocle, met my friend. She was already there and everybody was just like in shock. Everyone in there, the waiters, the people who had been there. There were just a few people who had been there because they served breakfast in there upstairs. So, anyway, then after that, I got a call from a friend of mine who worked for the State Department and he had been evacuated and he said, why don't you come over and let's continue watching the events unfold. And he lived in Adams Morgan, so I drove over there and it was the eeriest thing driving down Pennsylvania Avenue because there was not, it was like a ghost town. There was not a soul around except for police.

Martha Herrmann: I wonder if by that time, I remember Bush was in Florida when it happened. I wonder if by that time he was back. Because you know, they would have sent him back on the special plane.

Laura Parker: Didn't he fly around and kind of eat up some time a little bit before he came back?

Martha Herrmann: I'm not remembering.

Scarlett Bunting: That sounds familiar.

Martha Herrmann: But anyway, so then driving home, what time roughly? Do you have any recollection?

Kerry McKenney: I would say it was probably 7:00 or 8:00 at night because I stayed over at my friend's for a while and we talked.

Martha Herrmann: And you were able to use 395 and was it the 14th Street bridge you came across? Okay. And you got home. All right, Laura, tell us about the rest of your day.

Laura Parker: Well, so the members of Congress were hungry for information. So, they all gathered over at the Capitol Police headquarters, which is right next to the Monocle. So, that's why the street was closed that day. So, everybody's just clamoring for information. So, they stayed there all afternoon, just trying to see what they were going to do. And finally, you may remember they all went back over to the Capitol steps and the Speaker of the House made a little speech and then they all just broke out into song and sang God Bless America on the steps of the Capitol to show unity with the House, the Senate, the Democrats, the Republicans. So, that was kind of a meaningful thing for me to get to see. But let me back up and say what I did when we all got over to the Capitol Police headquarters. My boss asked me if I would go back into the Capitol and get his briefcase because he left it.

Kerry McKenney: He didn't really ask. He kind of ordered, didn't he?

Laura Parker: So, at least he got a Capitol Police officer to escort me over there.

Martha Herrmann: Gee, how thoughtful.

Kerry McKenney: Yeah, really.

Laura Parker: And he picked a woman.

Kerry McKenney: A woman police officer.

Laura Parker: Of course. So, anyway,

Scarlett Bunting: Because we're expendable.

Laura Parker: Right. Right. I went in there and it was a surreal, just so eerily quiet. Drawers were open at people's desks, and a gift shop was there. All the items were still out on display. So, I kind of thought, oh my gosh, I hope a terrorist hadn't been hiding in here and waiting to blow up the Capitol. But anyway, that was that was one chore I did that day that I'll always remember.

Kerry McKenney: I remember it's kind of a funny story that you told me about, well, some members of Congress, as I'm sure you know, like to grandstand and everything. So, there was a briefing going on, security briefing over at police headquarters. And they were saying, we're going to evaluate the situation before we decide if we're going to reopen the Capitol. So, one member, I won't say who he was, but he stood up and said, we are not going to close the Capitol. This is the United States of America. We are not doing that. And then I will say her name, Senator Barbara Boxer. She said to him, sit down. These people are professionals. And he sat down.

Martha Herrmann: Oh, that's a great story. So, Laura, you spent the day up there then just I guess watching and waiting for news?

Laura Parker: Waiting for news. Yep, waiting to see if we could go back into the Capitol. And they did. I guess they did. But it was dark by the time they went back over there to the steps of the Capitol. So,

Martha Herrmann: Were you all able to talk to each other or did you talk to each other at all that

Laura Parker: Our phones, I think maybe once or twice, but it was a while because the phones were totally jammed.

Kerry McKenney: And all the family members, and there were rumors going around that the Capitol had been bombed.

Martha Herrmann: Exactly. Nobody could get through. And that there was a bomb at the State Department. I remember that rumor too.

Kerry McKenney: So, you know, my sister, my niece are all worried and calling, and your family members too, I'm sure. And so, yeah, we didn't really

Martha Herrmann: So, Laura, how'd you get home?

Laura Parker: Well, I drove home, but it seems like it was 11:30 or 12:00 at night.

Martha Herrmann: Because it was so empty or

Kerry McKenney: I thought it was later than that. Like 2:00 in the morning, I don't know, but maybe that was another

Martha Herrmann: So,

Kerry McKenney: Because you worked late a lot of nights after that.

Martha Herrmann: So, you came home late and could you take the normal roads also because they were empty?

Laura Parker: Yeah. I took the normal roads by the, I was literally the only one on the road from the Capitol back to here, back to Fairlington. And looking over to the right to see the Pentagon smoldering, smoking a lot. And that happened for several days as you know.

Martha Herrmann: When I saw it, it was like somebody punched me in the stomach.

Kerry McKenney: Yeah, and waking up the next morning, you're not sure if this was all a nightmare or

Martha Herrmann: So, let's go then to the next day. So, you both stayed home the next day or did you have to go to work?

Laura Parker: Yeah, went back.

Martha Herrmann: So, did you drive back?

Laura Parker: Um

Martha Herrmann: And they didn't have roads?

Laura Parker: There were barricades up by the Capitol, I think, but the big ID.

Kerry McKenney: We were able to park in a regular parking place in the garage and everything.

Martha Herrmann: Do you remember anything you all were working on? You were removed from Fairlington. You were on the hill. But do you remember at all what it was like in Fairlington on the next few days?

Kerry McKenney: I just remember seeing people and everybody was still kind of in shock and just you might have been out walking. People saying, oh, it's terrible, you know, it's awful.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah. And I imagine it was real quiet.

Laura Parker: Yeah.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah.

Kerry McKenney: I think a lot of people were still inside watching the news coverage.

Martha Herrmann: What would you say were some of the biggest changes you saw after 9/11? By changes, I mean in your daily habits, in what you saw other people doing, in what you saw around town, in terms of security or thoughts.

Kerry McKenney: On the Capitol, everything changed. When I first started working on the hill, I can remember if I would have company in town and I wanted to show them around the Capitol, I could drive right up and park at the foot of the Capitol steps. I mean, it was totally open. And it did change a little bit. They had a kiosk there, I think, but it was nothing like after 9/11.

Everybody was on high alert and then they started constructing barricades and I think tour

buses were not allowed within a certain distance. I mean, just the whole feel of the place changed.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah. You noticed anything?

Laura Parker: And nobody was allowed to fly for the longest time. And I do remember going home for Thanksgiving. I thought I would fly on Thanksgiving morning because I didn't think anybody would be out there at 6:00 in the morning, but that place was jam-packed. But that was the first time I had flown.

Martha Herrmann: Was that National Airport or Dulles?

Laura Parker: That was Dulles. It was Dulles.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah. Because it took a long time to reopen National, right? Dulles was open. And I remember walking down that Mount Vernon Trail and how odd it was, not seeing planes for, I don't know. How long was it? Like a month or two?

Scarlett Bunting: I thought it was only 4 days of complete grounding.

Martha Herrmann: Well, but National was much longer.

Scarlett Bunting: Yeah. Well, they had to rethink like the airspace and how they were going to handle flights coming over the city and

Martha Herrmann: Yeah.

Kerry McKenney: I was nervous the first couple times and I'd never been a nervous flyer. I was always very relaxed. Thought it was fun to fly and everything, but I was tense.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah. Did you talk to any neighbors around here? Did you know neighbors around here?

Kerry McKenney: I don't remember any long conversations.

Martha Herrmann: Yeah.

Laura Parker: I just remember getting up early, going to work early, coming home late. Yeah. But it was always, it's nice when you turned into Fairlington though. You kind of just felt safe and

Kerry McKenney: Safe and

Scarlett Bunting: You're home.

Kerry McKenney: Right.

Martha Herrmann: Do you have any other thoughts in general you want to say about that day, that time?

Kerry McKenney: Well, I think it's important just to think about the people who were lost and to remember them.

Martha Herrmann: Did you know anybody?

Kerry McKenney: I didn't know anyone personally. We have a friend, talking about Tim Daugherty, a friend whose fiancée was working in the Pentagon and this guy had been single for a long time. He was probably in his late 40s, I would say, and he finally met this woman and they had gotten engaged and he was just over the moon. He was so happy. And she was working in the Pentagon and she was inside that was hit and she, he tried for days, because people were standing outside the Pentagon waiting to see if anybody would walk out, but unfortunately she was killed. And he said her daughter called him, and I guess, once it became apparent that she had been lost, the daughter said, I just wish mom had listened to me because she said she called her mother when all this was happening in New York and she said, mom, please go out of the building. Please leave the building. And she said, no, honey, we're fine

here. Everything's okay. So, that was just heartbreaking. And then I remember the Sunday New York Times that I get for months because so many people were killed, they had pages

Martha Herrmann: And searching. People were searching because

Kerry McKenney: Yes.

Martha Herrmann: they didn't know.

Kerry McKenney: But they had something called Portraits of Grief and so it was kind of nice that they had a little bio or something of every person or what that person meant to their family. And so, I think for me, it's really important to remember what we lost. I mean, it's one thing just to, right. It's one thing to just have a ceremony and hear a few speeches or something, but I think it really personalized it when you read about the people there, especially a lot of young people and their aspirations and some of them were at their first job at the World Trade Center. So,

Martha Herrmann: Yeah. You have any thoughts in general?

Laura Parker: Well, no. I do think it's important to remember. And my friend's grandson actually said that he was having a project in school and they were talking about 9/11 and he was supposed to interview two people. So, he interviewed me. And I thought that was good of the teacher to help them remember. And that little guy's sister, who was 3 years younger than him, she interviewed me too. So,

Martha Herrmann: Oh, how sweet.

Scarlett Bunting: How long ago was that?

Laura Parker: That was, oh gosh, I was looking at it today. Well, he's in college now, so he just started college.

Martha Herrmann: Isn't that amazing, all these people that don't know anything? And that's one of the reasons we wanted to do this. Is that so others could actually hear. The Arlington Historical Society has a lot more as well. But we just thought since we were in Fairlington, get people who were in Fairlington.

Kerry McKenney: Yeah, that's a great idea because it's such a large community, but at the same time, kind of a tight-knit community.

Martha Herrmann: But a lot of people come and go too. So, it's so wonderful to meet people who are here who have been here for so long.

Kerry McKenney: I'm always amazed if I meet someone new at a party or something and they say, where do you live? And I say, Fairlington. Oh, well that, but I bought my first house there. My daughter lives there now. Everybody seems to have a connection.

Scarlett Bunting: I know. Some of them lived here. They had a good friend that lived here. Right. Yeah, everyone knows Fairlington.

Martha Herrmann: Well, on that note, thank you Laura. Thank you Kerry. Thank you

Kerry McKenney: Oh, thank you guys. What a great project.

Martha Herrmann: So much for talking to us.

Kerry McKenney: Oh, well happy to do it. And good luck with the project.